

How to use Vi Text Editor?

Vi uses the basic format of editing and does not follow up with fancy projections like others. Here you will not retrieve a text which looks precisely as it is presented on your screen. The editor lets you change, delete and add text to your file but does not allow you to do additional formatting such as paragraph indenting and line centring. Let's look at the basics of Vi text editor.

Opening the Vi Text Editor

To launch the Vi Text Editor, open the terminal and type the following:

`vi <filename_EXISTING>` where "filename" is the name of that file which is already existing in the memory of the Text Editor. You can also create a new file by entering the command, `<filename_NEW>`.

If you do not remember the name of the file, you have to enter the entire pathname of the file. If the file that you want to open does not exist, it will show a screen with only a cursor and the tilde (~) sign will occur in the first column.

Operating modes of Vi Text Editor

There are 2 modes of Vi Text Editor-

- Command Mode
- Insert Mode

Command Mode:

The default mode on the Vi Text Editor is the Command Mode. In Command mode, essential functions are performed by giving commands. These include moving around in the file, making changes and to exiting that particular file. These commands are executed not by using any specific key but by using the alphabetical keys present on the QWERTY Keyboard.

Commands given in the command mode are in the form of alphabetical mode but are case sensitive. "I" is not the same as "i". Commands given in the command mode when processed, do not appear on the screen as you enter them but instead they appear in the last line. When you are giving commands in the Command Mode of Vi Text Editor, you have to hit colon `<:>` to take the cursor to the last line of the text and then enter the command and hit `<enter>`.

For example, if you want to save a particular file, then, first hit `<:>` and then "w" and hit `<enter>`. Taking the cursor to the last line of the file is also called the last-line mode or command line mode.

Insert Mode:

This is the mode in which the text is created. You can switch to this mode from the Command Mode by pressing "i", on the Command Mode. While creating